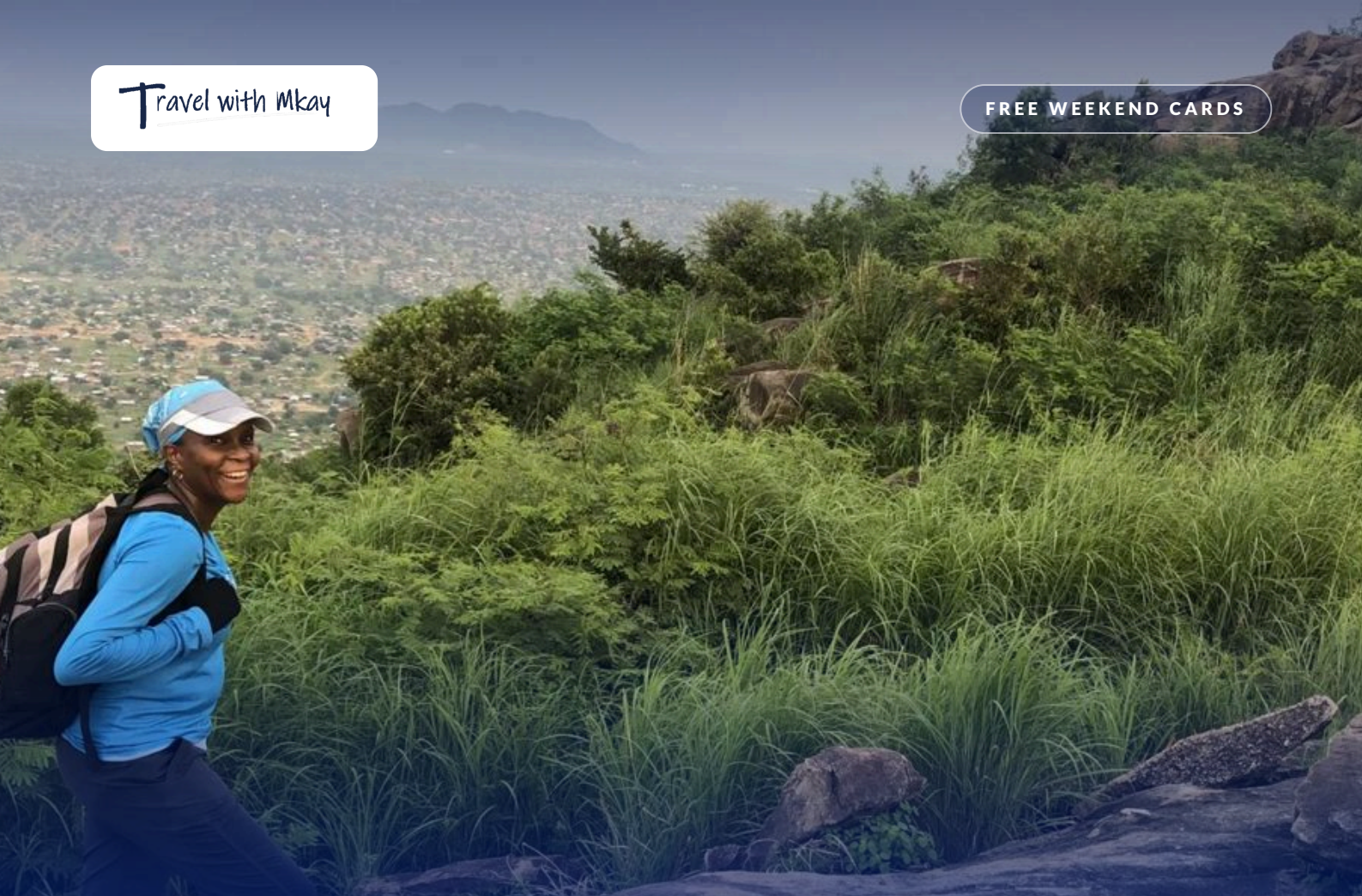
Travel with Mkay

FREE WEEKEND CARDS



UPDATED NOVEMBER 2026 · PRICES IN KSH

10 weekends out of Nairobi, each under *KSh 10,000*

Where to catch the matatu, what the gate costs and how to pay it, what to carry and the best months to go. One page per weekend.



YOUR GUIDE

Hi, I'm Maria (Mkay)

I'm an ICF-certified travel coach, born and raised in Kenya. I have traveled to 100 countries on an ordinary Kenyan passport and explored all 47 Kenyan counties. People tell me they want adventure but aren't sure they can afford it. These ten weekends are my answer.

100	47	10	1,300
countries visited	Kenyan counties	weekends in this guide	KSh, the cheapest one

START HERE

Your ten weekends

Each one has its own page with the route, the gate fee, the best months and what to sort before you leave. Prices are per person, all in.



Ngong Hills

25 km · Day trip

KSh 1,300

p. 4



Lake Naivasha & Hell's Gate

90 to 110 km · One night

KSh 4,300

p. 5



Thika & Fourteen Falls

50 to 65 km · Day or one night

KSh 3,450

p. 6



Machakos

65 km · Day or one night

KSh 3,450

p. 7



Mt. Longonot

90 km · Day trip

KSh 2,100

p. 8



Limuru & Kereita Forest

30 to 70 km · Day trip

KSh 3,300

p. 9



Nakuru & Menengai Crater

160 km · One night

KSh 3,600

p. 10



Nanyuki & Mt. Kenya

180 to 200 km · One night

KSh 3,400

p. 11



Sagana

95 km · One night

KSh 7,900

p. 12



Ol Donyo Sabuk

65 km · Day trip

KSh 1,700

p. 13

Which one is yours?

GOING AS A COUPLE

A night by the lake among zebras, tea-country fireplaces, or the Friday train to the foot of Mt. Kenya. **Weekends 02, 06, 08**

WITH CHILDREN

Free entry at Machakos, or crocodiles and colobus monkeys at Blue Post. At KWS scenic parks, ages 6 to 17 pay KSh 250, under-6s go free. **Weekends 04, 03**

ONLY HAVE A DAY

All about an hour out: Ngong Hills, Limuru, Thika and Fourteen Falls, Ol Donyo Sabuk, Machakos. **Weekends 01, 06, 03, 10, 04**

TIGHTEST BUDGET

Ngong Hills from KSh 1,300, Ol Donyo Sabuk from KSh 1,700, Mt. Longonot from KSh 2,100, all in. **Weekends 01, 10, 05**

WANT A THRILL

White water rafting on the Tana, East Africa's longest zip line, or a volcano rim before breakfast. **Weekends 09, 06, 05**

THE JOURNEY IS THE TRIP

The Nanyuki safari train: KSh 400 each way in economy, through the highlands, every Friday. **Weekends 08**

BEFORE YOU LEAVE NAIROBI

Ten minutes now saves the trip

No cash

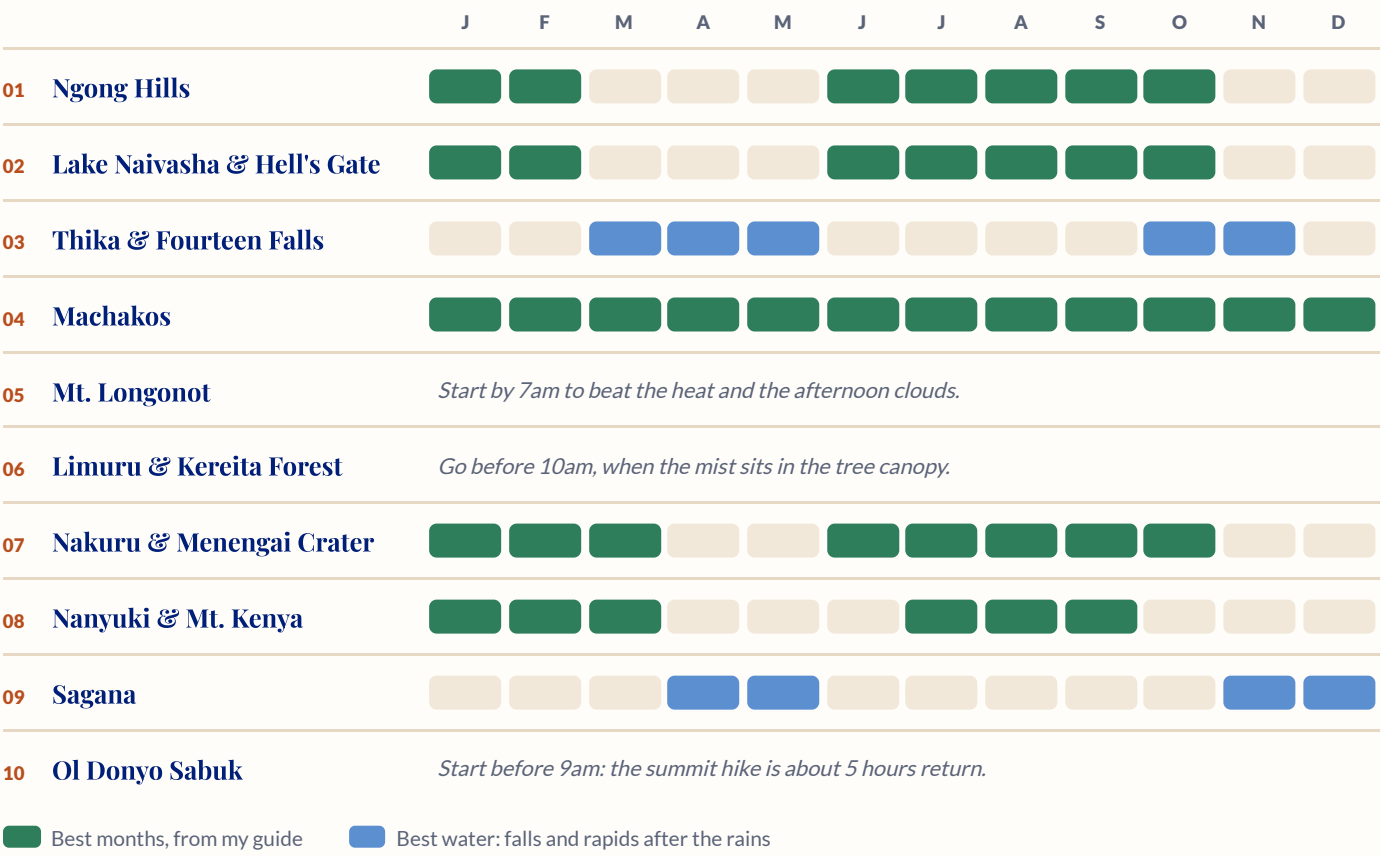
KWS park gates do not take cash

Hell's Gate, Mt. Longonot, Ol Donyo Sabuk and Mt. Kenya are paid on eCitizen or KWSPay with M-Pesa. The Forest at Kereita is M-Pesa only. Set up eCitizen and link M-Pesa before the day: it takes about 10 minutes.

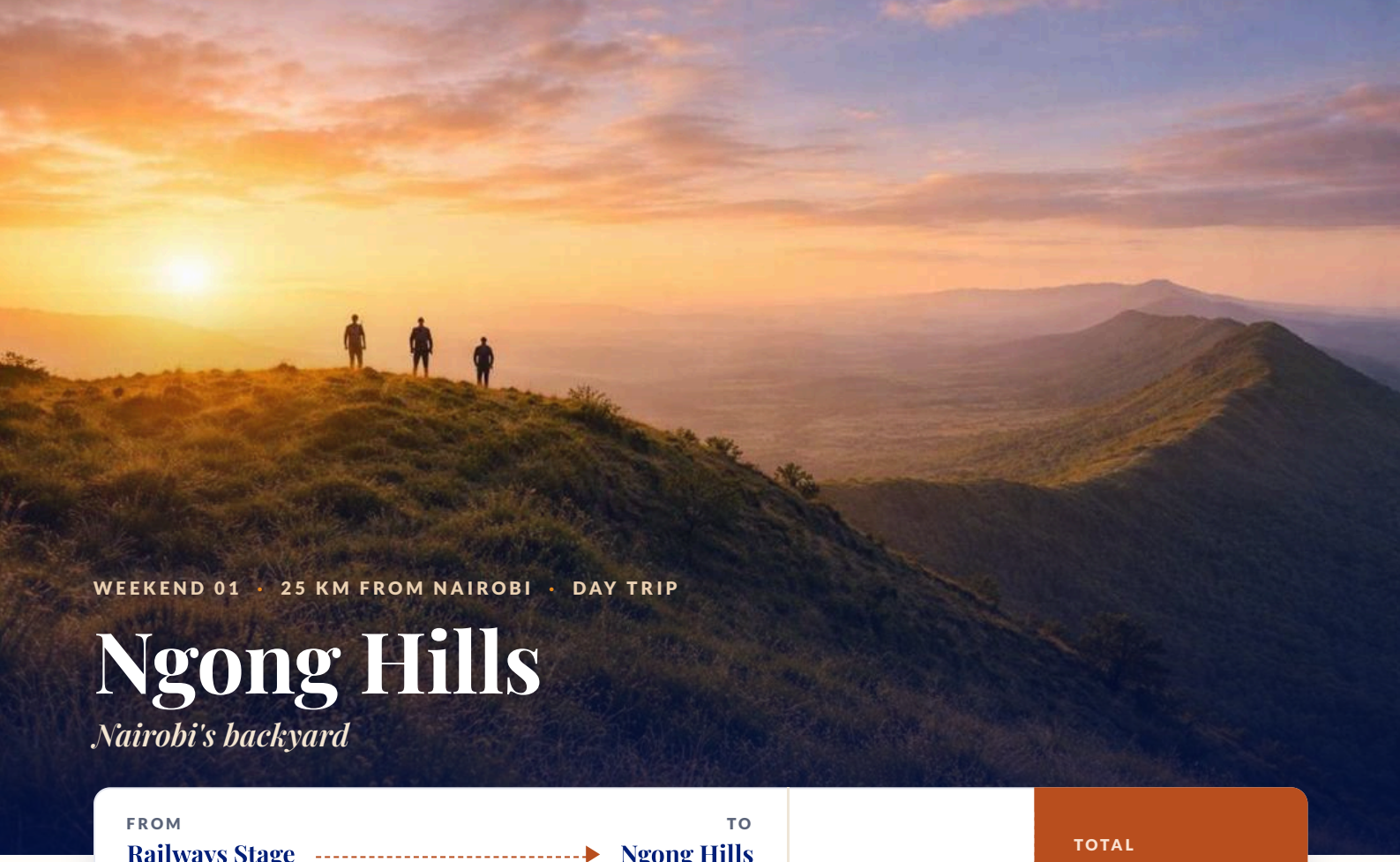
- [ ] eCitizen account set up, M-Pesa linked
- [ ] Your ID: the fees in this guide are citizen adult rates
- [ ] Leave early: most gates open at 6am
- [ ] M-Pesa topped up for gates and zip lines
- [ ] Small cash for matatus and boda bodas
- [ ] Check the forecast the day before

SEASONS AT A GLANCE

When each weekend is at its best



Kenya has rains, not summer and winter. The long rains fall around March to May and the short rains around October to November. Trails get slippery and gorges can flood, so have a plan B: Machakos stays warm and dry when Nairobi is grey.



WEEKEND 01 · 25 KM FROM NAIROBI · DAY TRIP

Ngong Hills

Nairobi's backyard

FROM	TO	AT THE GATE	TOTAL
Railways Stage	Ngong Hills	KSh 200	KSh 1,300 all in, per person

Matatu 111 to Ngong Town, then a boda to the gate

BEST MONTHS

Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
●	●				●	●	●	●	●		

Avoid it after heavy rain: the trail turns slippery and you lose the views.

GETTING THERE

Matatu Route 111 from Railways Stage (opposite Memorial Park) to Ngong Town, KSh 50 to 100. Boda boda to the Forest Reserve gate, KSh 100.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

KSh 200 (citizen adult). The hike only needs the entry ticket. Zip line KSh 700, bike hire KSh 500 for 3 hours.

WHAT TO CARRY

A warm layer (it's cold up there even in the dry season), snacks and water: there's nothing on the trail.

Sort before you leave

- [ ] Your entry ticket, the afternoon before. It gets you the 6am gate opening instead of 8am.

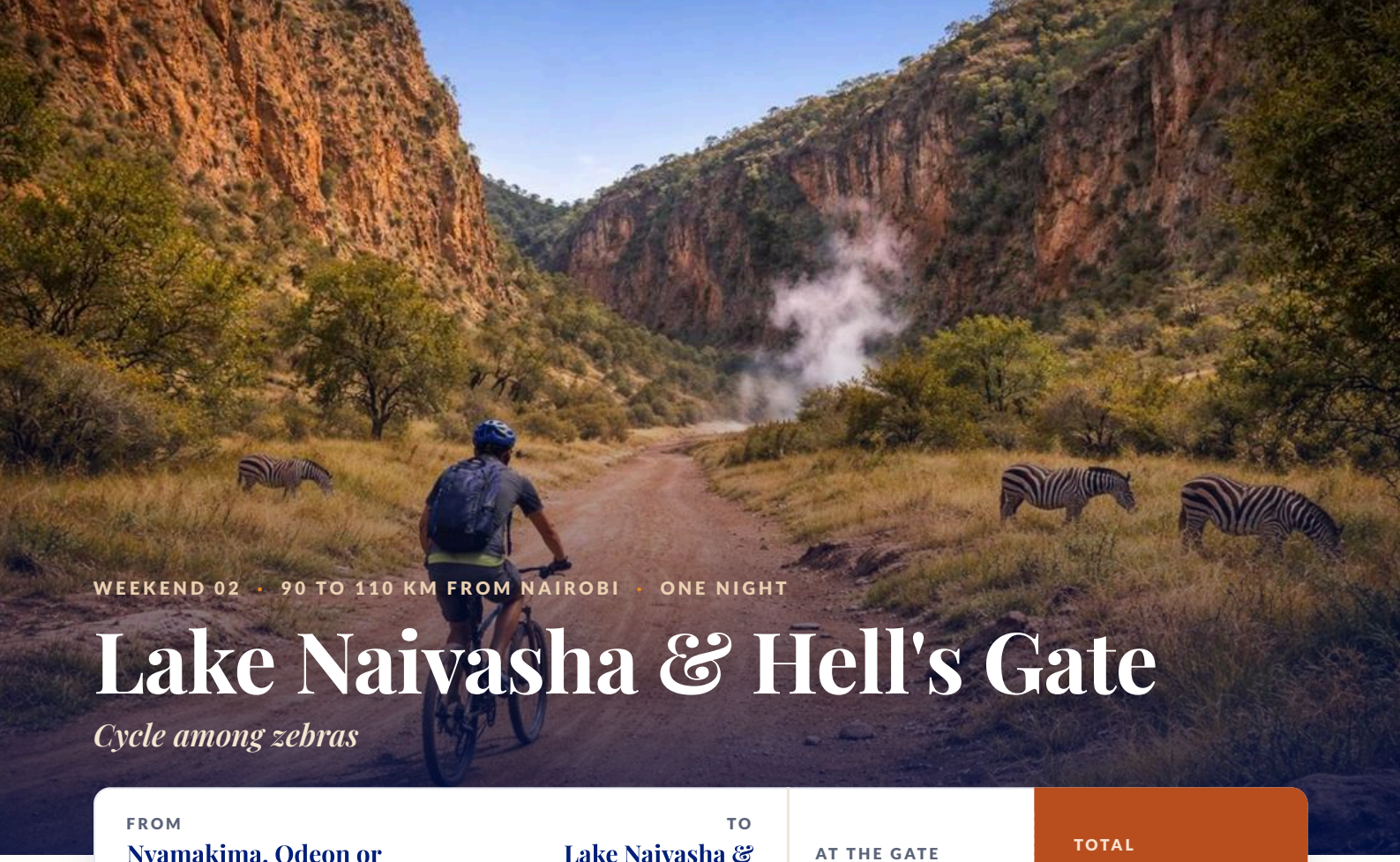
Pay on the day

- Matatu, KSh 50 to 100
- Boda to the gate, KSh 100



"The morning light on the Rift Valley from the first peak is something else entirely."

MARIA'S TIP



WEEKEND 02 · 90 TO 110 KM FROM NAIROBI · ONE NIGHT

Lake Naivasha & Hell's Gate

Cycle among zebras

FROM	TO	AT THE GATE	TOTAL
Nyamakima, Odeon or Accra Road	Lake Naivasha & Hell's Gate	KSh 500 + 300 cycling	KSh 4,300 to 5,400 per person

Matatu to Naivasha (1.5 to 2 hrs), then the 'Kongoni' matatu

BEST MONTHS

Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
●	●				●	●	●	●	●		

The gorge walk may close in heavy rains (March to May).

GETTING THERE

Matatu from Nyamakima, Odeon or Accra Road, KSh 300 to 500 one way (1.5 to 2 hours). Then the 'Kongoni' matatu to Hell's Gate, KSh 100 to 150.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

CASHLESS GATE

Hell's Gate KSh 500 (citizen, KWS scenic park) + cycling fee KSh 300. Bike hire at Elsa Gate KSh 400 to 600: bargain a little.

WHAT TO CARRY

Sunscreen and water for the cycle, a warm layer for the night by the lake, your own tent if camping.

Sort before you leave

- ☐ Hell's Gate entry on eCitizen. The park is cashless.

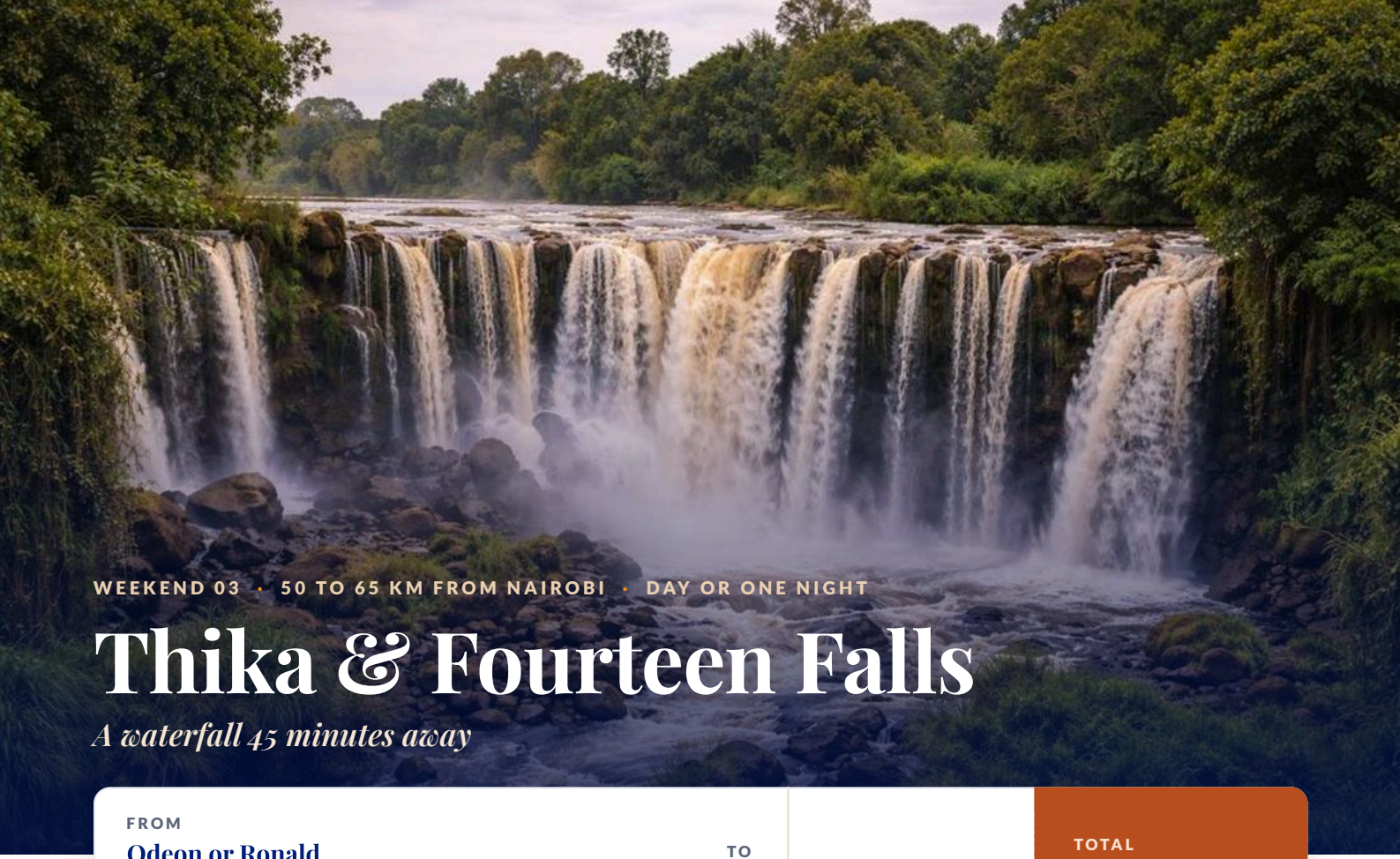
Pay on the day

- Matatus, KSh 300 to 500 + 100 to 150
- Bike hire at Elsa Gate, KSh 400 to 600
- Fisherman's Camp, KSh 900 with your own tent



"Start Hell's Gate by 7am for the morning light on the cliffs. At the lake, agree the Crescent Island boat price before you get in.

MARIA'S TIP



WEEKEND 03 · 50 TO 65 KM FROM NAIROBI · DAY OR ONE NIGHT

Thika & Fourteen Falls

A waterfall 45 minutes away

FROM
Odeon or Ronald Ngala Street ⇢ TO **Thika & Fourteen Falls**

Matatu 237 to Thika, then towards Kilimambogo + boda

AT THE GATE
KSh 200

TOTAL
KSh 3,450
to 5,450 with a night

BEST WATER

Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
		■	■	■					■	■	

Most impressive during or just after the rains. The dry season gives clearer access to the riverbank.

GETTING THERE

Matatu Route 237 from Odeon or Ronald Ngala Street, KSh 150 to 300. From Thika, matatu from Makongeni Stage towards Kilimambogo, then boda to the falls.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

Fourteen Falls KSh 200 (citizens). Blue Post Hotel nature park KSh 150 per adult: crocodiles, ostriches, colobus monkeys.

WHAT TO CARRY

Shoes with grip for the wet rocks, a plastic bag for your phone near the spray.

Sort before you leave

- ☐ A guesthouse in Thika or Juja (KSh 1,000 to 2,500) if you stay over

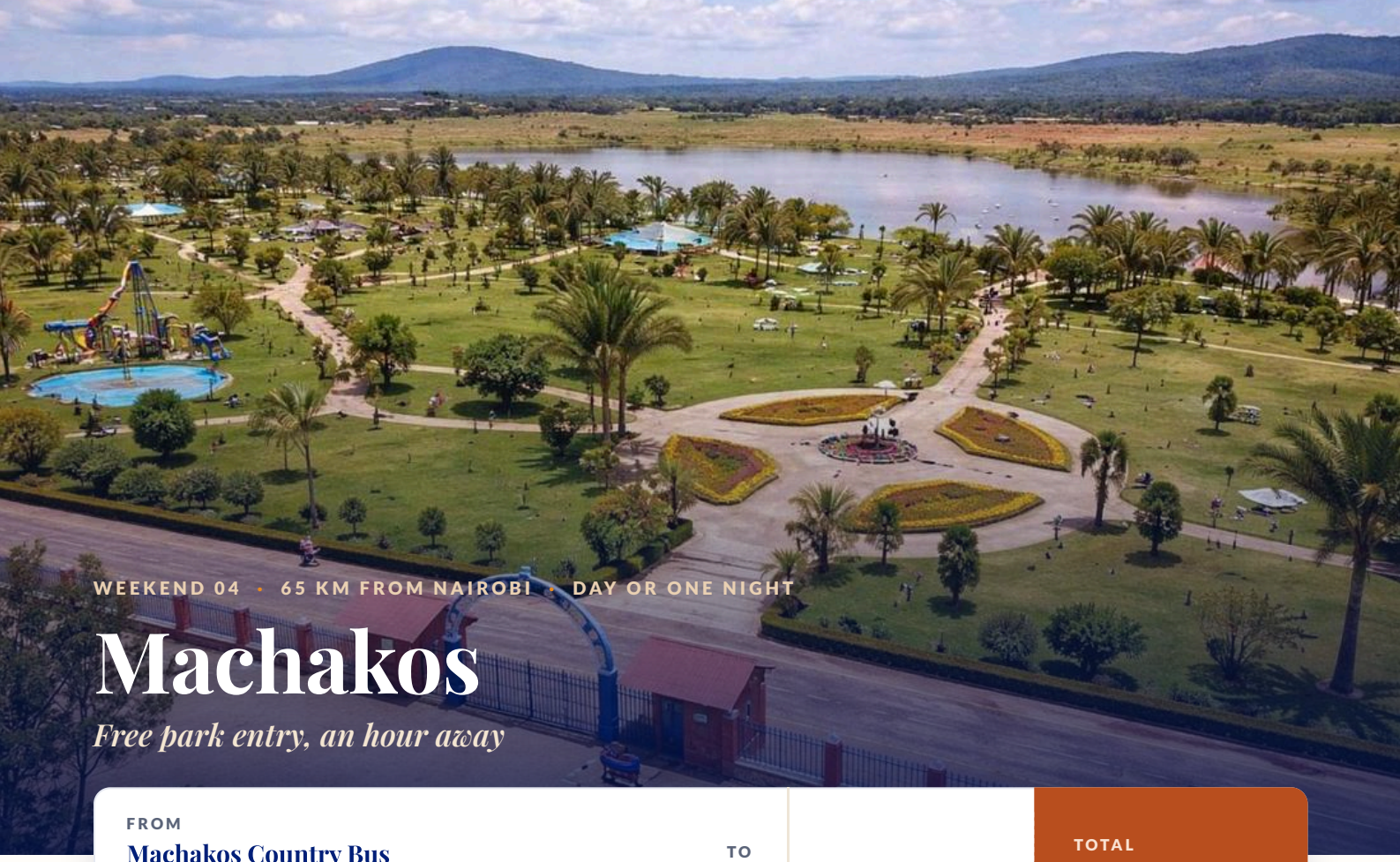
Pay on the day

- Fourteen Falls and Blue Post entries
- Matatus and boda



"Go early on a weekday: it gets busy on weekend afternoons. Combine with Ol Donyo Sabuk (page 13) for a 2-in-1 weekend.

MARIA'S TIP



WEEKEND 04 · 65 KM FROM NAIROBI · DAY OR ONE NIGHT

Machakos

Free park entry, an hour away

FROM
Machakos Country Bus Station, Muthurwa

TO
Machakos

Matatu (very frequent), then a boda or tuk-tuk

AT THE GATE
Free

TOTAL
KSh **3,450**
to 5,850 with a night

ALL YEAR

Jan Feb Mar Apr May Jun Jul Aug Sep Oct Nov Dec

Semi-arid: it stays warm and dry when Nairobi is having one of its grey rainy stretches.

GETTING THERE

Matatu from Machakos Country Bus Station near Muthurwa, KSh 200 to 400. Very frequent. Boda or tuk-tuk to People's Park, KSh 100 to 200.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

People's Park and Iveti Hills hiking: FREE. Zip line inside the park KSh 550 (two zips).

WHAT TO CARRY

Sun hat and water, snacks for the children, comfortable shoes for the park paths.

Sort before you leave

- [ ] Machakos Inn, Garden Hotel (KSh 1,500 to 2,500) or Kyaka Hotel, if staying over

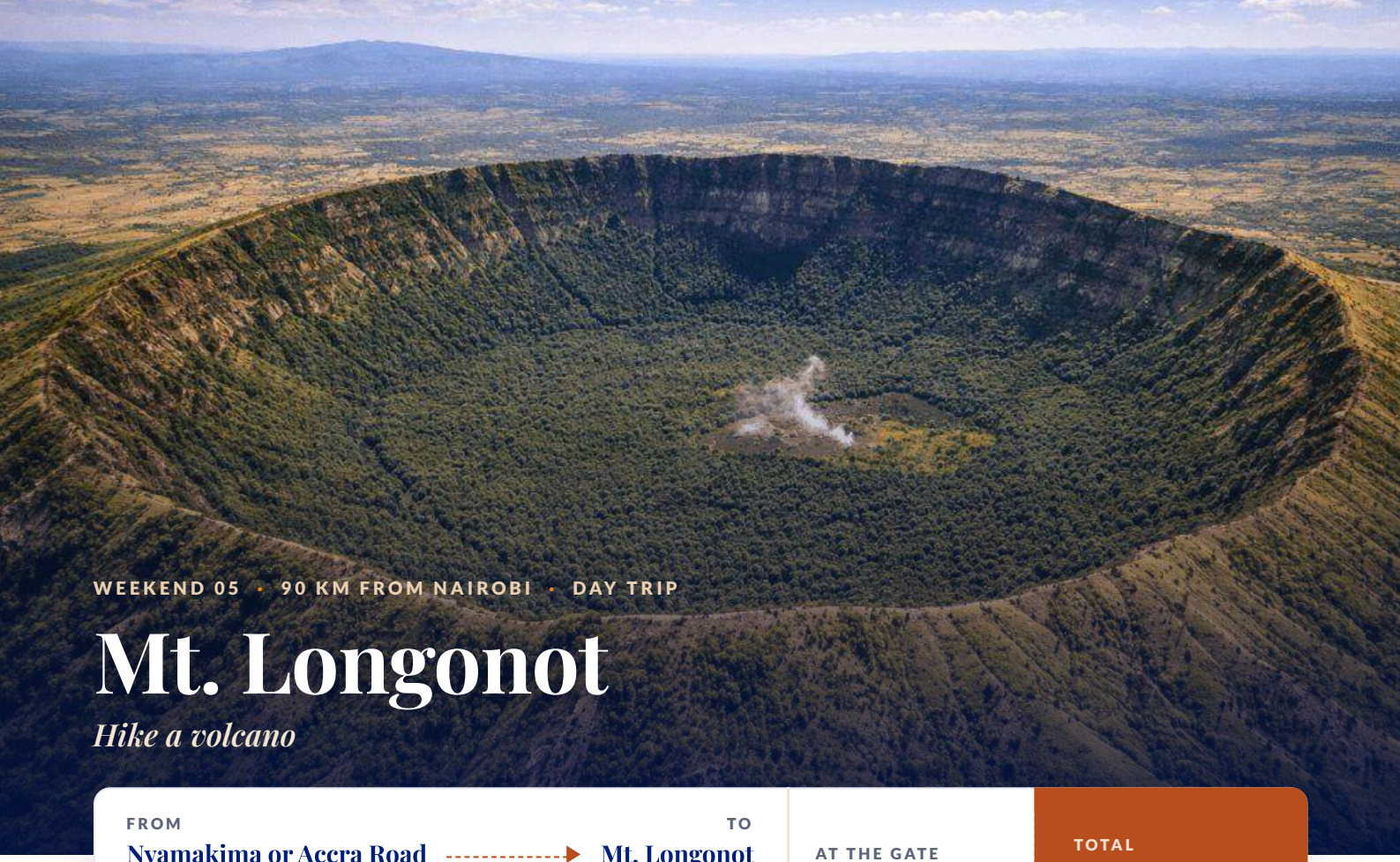
Pay on the day

- Everything else. Park entry is free.
- Zip line, KSh 550 for two zips



"If the long rains have you feeling cooped up, this is the escape that actually has sunshine.

MARIA'S TIP



WEEKEND 05 · 90 KM FROM NAIROBI · DAY TRIP

Mt. Longonot

Hike a volcano

FROM	TO	AT THE GATE	TOTAL
Nyamakima or Accra Road	Mt. Longonot	KSh 500, cashless	KSh 2,100 to 2,800 per person

Naivasha matatu, then a boda to the park gate

No set season in my guide. What matters is the hour.

Timing: Start by 7am to beat the heat and the afternoon clouds. Rim in 1.5 to 2 hours, full crater circuit another 2 to 3. Gates 6am to 6pm.

GETTING THERE

Same route as Naivasha (Nyamakima or Accra Road, KSh 300 to 500), then boda to the park gate, KSh 150 to 300.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

CASHLESS GATE

KSh 500 (citizen, KWS scenic park). Pay on eCitizen with M-Pesa BEFORE you arrive. The gate does not take cash.

WHAT TO CARRY

2+ litres of water (nothing on the trail), proper shoes for the loose-rock descent, a packed lunch.

Sort before you leave

- [ ] Entry on eCitizen with M-Pesa. The gate takes no cash.

Pay on the day

- Matatu, KSh 300 to 500
- Boda to the gate, KSh 150 to 300



"Pair it with Naivasha: Hell's Gate on Saturday, Longonot on Sunday, back in Nairobi by evening. Three experiences, one weekend."

MARIA'S TIP



WEEKEND 06 · 30 TO 70 KM FROM NAIROBI · DAY TRIP

Limuru & Kereita Forest

East Africa's longest zip line

FROM	TO	AT THE GATE	TOTAL
Khoja Stage, near Kencom	Limuru & Kereita Forest	KSh 200 + zip, M-Pesa only	KSh 3,300 to 3,900 per person

Matatu 114 to Limuru, towards Kimende, then a boda

No set season in my guide. What matters is the hour.

Timing: Go before 10am, when the mist sits in the tree canopy. Midweek is quieter.

GETTING THERE

Matatu Route 114 from Khoja Stage near Kencom to Limuru, KSh 80 to 200. Matatu towards Kimende, then boda to The Forest gate, KSh 200 to 400.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY M-PESA ONLY

Forest entry KSh 200. 2-line zip (750 m) KSh 1,800 to 2,100, 6-line zip (2.2 km) KSh 2,800 to 3,250. M-Pesa only, no cash.

WHAT TO CARRY

A warm layer for the highland mist, closed shoes for the zip line, a full M-Pesa balance.

Sort before you leave

- [ ] The Kentmere Club in Tigoni (B&B from KSh 2,000 per person), if staying
- [ ] Top up M-Pesa: the gate and zips take nothing else

Pay on the day

- Entry and zips, by M-Pesa
- Matatus and boda



"The forest is at its most magical in the early morning, with mist in the canopy. The whole thing is very cinematic.

MARIA'S TIP



WEEKEND 07 · 160 KM FROM NAIROBI · ONE NIGHT

Nakuru & Menengai Crater

A KSh 200 volcanic caldera

FROM	TO	AT THE GATE	TOTAL
Accra Road, Tea Room or Muthurwa	Nakuru & Menengai Crater	KSh 200	KSh 3,600 to 6,100 per person
Matatu or shuttle, 2.5 to 3 hours			

BEST MONTHS: **Jan** **Feb** **Mar** Apr May **Jun** **Jul** **Aug** **Sep** **Oct** Nov Dec

GETTING THERE

Matatu or shuttle from Accra Road, Tea Room or Muthurwa, KSh 400 to 700 one way (2.5 to 3 hours). Easy Coach or Greenline KSh 1,000 to 1,200.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

Menengai Crater KSh 200 (Kenya Forest Service). Hyrax Hill site and museum KSh 100. Lake Nakuru NP is extra: KSh 1,500 per citizen adult + KSh 600 per small car.

WHAT TO CARRY

Hiking shoes and water for the crater rim, a light jacket for the evening.

Sort before you leave

- ☐ Lake Nakuru NP on KWSPay, if you add it
- ☐ An Airbnb or guesthouse, from KSh 1,300

Pay on the day

- Menengai and Hyrax Hill entries
- Matatu or shuttle, KSh 400 to 700



"Try Gilani's, a Nakuru institution for decades. Going up on a Friday evening? The 2NK shuttle from Tea Room is reliably on time.

MARIA'S TIP



WEEKEND 08 · 180 TO 200 KM FROM NAIROBI · ONE NIGHT

Nanyuki & Mt. Kenya

Ride the KSh 400 train

FROM	TO	AT THE GATE	TOTAL
Safari train, Fridays 9am	Nanyuki & Mt. Kenya	KSh 800 / 24 hrs	KSh 3,400 to 5,000 per person

Arrives 4:49pm. Back Sunday 9am, arrives 4:46pm

BEST MONTHS

Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
●	●	●				●	●	●			

Cloud rolls in by midday, so be on the trail before 9am.

GETTING THERE

Safari train every Friday 9am, arrives 4:49pm; back Sunday 9am, arrives 4:46pm. KSh 400 economy, KSh 1,000 first class. Or matatu (4NTE, Chakana) KSh 700 to 1,000.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

CASHLESS GATE

Mt. Kenya National Park KSh 800 per 24 hours (citizen). Public campsite KSh 200 a night. All fees on KWSPay (cashless).

WHAT TO CARRY

A warm, waterproof layer even in July: altitude and Kenyan weather are unpredictable together.

Sort before you leave

- [ ] Call Kenya Railways on 0709 907 000 to confirm the train and how to buy. It is NOT on the SGR booking site.
- [ ] Park and campsite fees on KWSPay

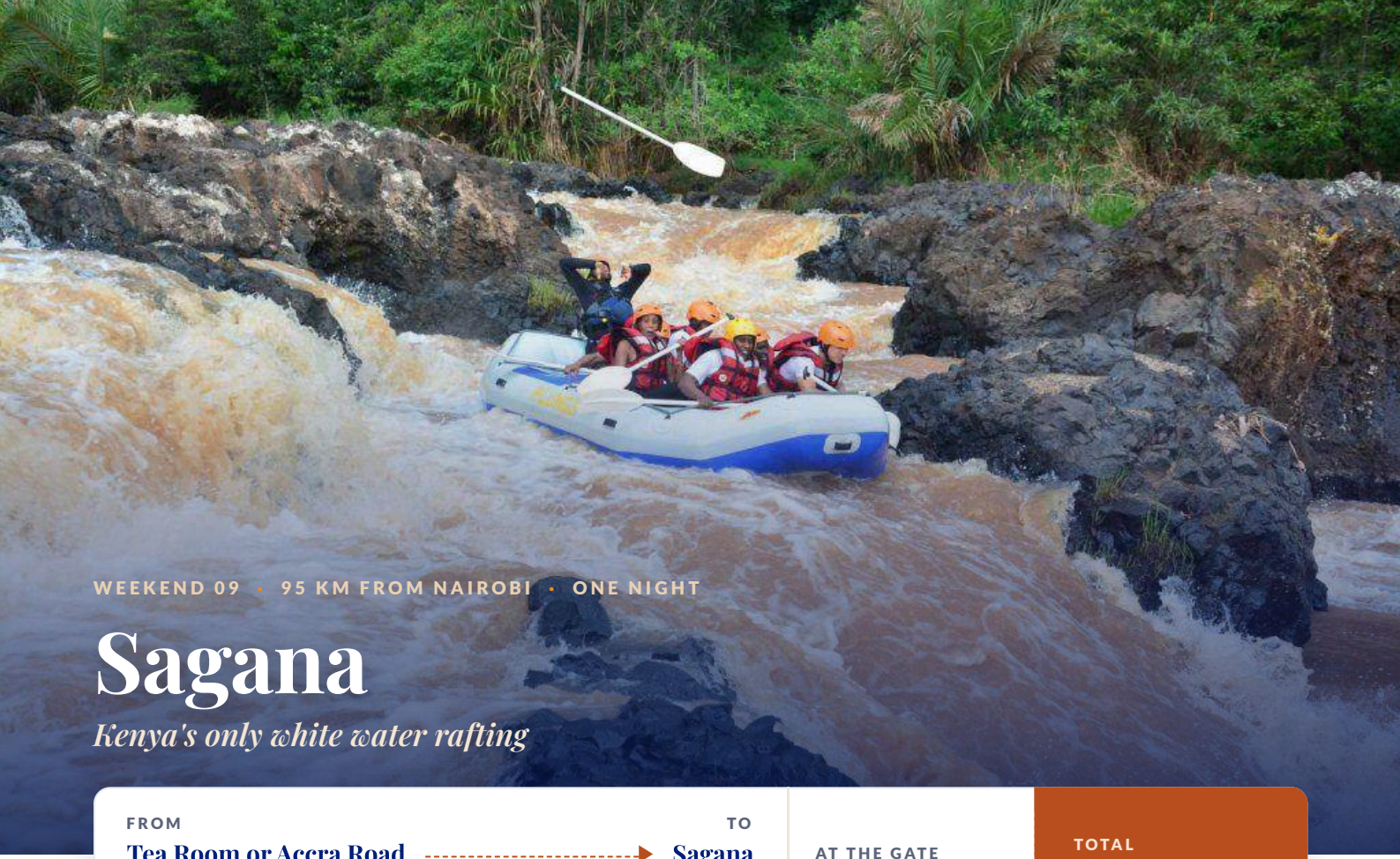
Pay on the day

- Matatu instead of the train (4NTE, Chakana), KSh 700 to 1,000



"Stand on the equator line in Nanyuki: the photo costs nothing. Trout Tree Restaurant is the bucket-list lunch if you can stretch it.

MARIA'S TIP



WEEKEND 09 · 95 KM FROM NAIROBI · ONE NIGHT

Sagana

Kenya's only white water rafting

FROM	TO	AT THE GATE	TOTAL
Tea Room or Accra Road	Sagana	Rafting from KSh 5,500	KSh 7,900 to 10,000 per person

Nyeri-bound matatu, alight at Sagana (1.5 to 2 hrs)

BEST WATER

Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
			●	●						●	●

Dry season rapids are calmer but still fun.

GETTING THERE

Nyeri-bound matatu from Tea Room or Accra Road, alight at Sagana, KSh 300 to 500 (1.5 to 2 hours). A shared car is easier if you can split fuel.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

Short rafting (1 to 2 hours) about KSh 5,500, long rafting KSh 7,750, bungee KSh 3,000 to 5,000. Camping KSh 1,000 to 2,000.

WHAT TO CARRY

Clothes you can get wet, a change of clothes, sandals that strap on, sunscreen. Self-catering supplies from Nairobi save the most.

Sort before you leave

- [ ] Call the camps directly (Rapids Camp, Savage Wilderness): direct rates are often better than online
- [ ] Groups of 4+: ask for a package

Pay on the day

- Matatu, KSh 300 to 500



"On the tightest budget, skip the rafting and do river trekking, rock climbing and a campfire night. The scenery alone is worth it."

MARIA'S TIP



WEEKEND 10 · 65 KM FROM NAIROBI · DAY TRIP

Ol Donyo Sabuk

The hidden gem

FROM	TO	AT THE GATE	TOTAL
Odeon or Ronald Ngala Street	Ol Donyo Sabuk	KSh 500, cashless	KSh 1,700 to 2,000 per person

Matatu 237 to Thika, towards Kilimambogo, then a boda

No set season in my guide. What matters is the hour.

Timing: Start before 9am: the summit hike is about 5 hours return. On a clear day you see Mt. Kenya and Kilimanjaro.

GETTING THERE

Thika-bound matatu (Route 237, KSh 150 to 300), then a matatu towards Kilimambogo (KSh 100 to 200) and a boda to the park gate (KSh 100 to 200).

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

CASHLESS GATE

KSh 500 (citizen, KWS scenic park). eCitizen and M-Pesa only. A KWS ranger guide goes with every hiker (buffalo are common).

WHAT TO CARRY

2+ litres of water, a rain jacket whatever the season (the upper forest is dense and wet), a packed lunch.

Sort before you leave

- [ ] Entry on eCitizen. The gate takes no cash.

Pay on the day

- Matatus and boda, about KSh 350 to 700
- Your KWS ranger guide walks with you



"Day one Fourteen Falls and Blue Post Hotel, day two an Ol Donyo Sabuk sunrise hike: two different landscapes, well under KSh 6,000."

MARIA'S TIP

PACKING

What goes in the bag

One list for every weekend, plus what to add when it's raining or when you're staying the night.

EVERY WEEKEND

The basics

- [ ] A warm layer: Ngong, Limuru and Nanyuki are cold even in the dry season
- [ ] A rain jacket, whatever the season
- [ ] 2 litres of water per person for hikes: there is nothing on the trails
- [ ] Proper shoes: Longonot's descent is loose rock
- [ ] Packed lunch and snacks
- [ ] Phone charged, eCitizen open, M-Pesa topped up
- [ ] ID for citizen rates

MARCH TO MAY, OCTOBER TO NOVEMBER

Rainy months

- [ ] Shoes with grip, and a spare pair of socks
- [ ] A dry bag or plastic bag for phone and ID
- [ ] A plan B: Machakos or Thika instead of a muddy hike
- [ ] Check that Hell's Gate gorge is open

STAYING THE NIGHT

Overnight

- [ ] Your own tent if camping (Fisherman's Camp, Ngong, Mt. Kenya)
- [ ] Headtorch and a warm sleeping layer

GOING SOON?

Best in November and December

- **Fourteen Falls (page 6)** is at its most impressive just after the rains.
- **Sagana (page 12)** has its best rafting water in November and December.
- **Machakos (page 7)** stays warm and dry when Nairobi is grey and rainy.



Weekend 02 · Hell's Gate by bike, among the zebras

STILL NOT SURE?

Not sure how to plan your trip? *Let's plan it together.*



Book a call with me and I'll walk you through everything you need for your next trip. We plan it together, so you can go and handle it on your own.

On the call we cover

- **Your destination** and the best time to go
- **What to book ahead** and what to pay on the day
- **What to pack** for the season
- **Your route:** how to get there and back
- **A realistic budget** for your dates
- **Your next steps,** so you travel without needing anyone

PRE-TRIP CONFIDENCE CALL

30 minutes with Maria

One call, your trip, a plan you can follow on your own.

1. **Pay** USD 10 by M-Pesa or card
2. **Pick** a time on my calendar
3. **Talk** it through with me

Book my USD 10 call

ONE CALL

USD 10

Scan to book

Enjoy the weekend. Send me a photo from the top.

Maria (Mkay) · @travelwithmkay · travelwithmkay.co.ke

Prices come from my guide "Weekend Getaways from Nairobi Under KSh 10,000", last updated 3 November 2026. Entry fees are citizen adult rates. Fares, fees and schedules change, so check the official source (KWS, Kenya Railways, the operator) before you pay.